



► **P.B. BALAJI HAS** become the latest in a long list of chief financial officers (CFOs) rising to the office of chief executive officers (CEOs) at global companies, epitomising a trajectory that's becoming the norm in a world characterised by flux.

The 54-year-old Group CFO of Tata Motors Ltd has been named CEO of Jaguar Land Rover Ltd (JLR) effective November 17, 2025, making him the first Indian to rise to the top position at the British luxury automobile maker. An alumnus of Indian Institute of Technology, Madras, and Indian Institute of Management, Calcutta, Balaji succeeds Adrian Mardell, who is retiring after a 35-year career at JLR, three of them as CEO.

Balaji, who previously worked at consumer goods giant Hindustan Unilever, brings financial discipline, strategic insights and boardroom credibility to JLR at a time the automaker is beset by challenges posed by US tariffs, a stalled transition to electric vehicles and pressure to reposition the brand.

Balaji's appointment also reflects a broader global trend: CFOs are increasingly stepping into top roles, capitalising on their perceived financial discipline and boardroom experience.

In 2023, 8.4% of vacant CEO positions in Fortune 500 and S&P 500 lists were filled by CFOs, the highest level since 2013, says CristKolder Associates, a corporate research group.

Closer home, a Russell Reynolds Associates' analysis of the top 100 BSE-listed companies, excluding the public sector, found that CFO turnover in 2024 surged to 24%, up sharply from 15% in 2023.

Of the 22 outgoing CFOs, 11 moved to new roles; the other half either retired or shifted to board-only

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positions. Notably, among those who took up new roles, 45% stayed with their companies, transitioning to CEO or divisional CEO positions.

What is driving this phenomenon?

"Business models are evolving rapidly. Think subscription services, platform economies. New financial instruments are emerging, from venture debt to crowdfunding and tokenisation," says Abhijit Bhaduri, a global talent advisor.

Numbers back Bhaduri's observation. Research by Russell Reynolds Associates shows that in 2022, 33% of S&P 500 CFOs who changed jobs became CEOs, compared to 8.8% the year before.

Its recent Global CFO Turnover Index covering S&P 500, FTSE 100, and Euronext 100 reveals that of the outgoing CFOs taking on new roles in 2024, 34% moved to President or CEO roles, up from 20% in 2023.

Another 15% moved to divisional CEO positions, up from 11%, while 6% transitioned to chief operating officer (COO) roles, up from 5%. And about 15% took on other C-Suite positions in corporate strategy or risk oversight roles—slightly down from last year.

ACROSS INDUSTRIES, GEOGRAPHIES

The transition is visible across industries and geographies. In India, in 2024, Nalin Negi stepped up as CEO of BharatPe, Manoj Bhat took the helm at Mahindra Holidays & Resorts Ltd, and Shrikant Kanhere assumed the role of Deputy CEO at Adani Wilmar, now known as AWL Agri Business Ltd.

Sreedhar N. of Cie de Saint Gobain SA, who served as Group CFO until April 2025, has now taken over as Senior Vice President and CEO for Asia Pacific and India. Similar moves include Aditya Pande's at InterGlobe Enterprises Ltd, Sanjay Dwivedi's at Balaji Telefilms Ltd, and Ved Prakash Goel's at Dr Lal Path-

15.1%

**WAS THE GLOBAL
CFO TURNOVER IN 2024,
JUST BELOW 2023'S
RECORD OF 16.2%**